SOCIOECONOMIC FALSE BELIEF #11 · DEBT AND SHAME

“My debt proves I'm irresponsible.”

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Where it often comes from

Debt can come from many roads: a job loss, an illness, a divorce, a family emergency, school, rising prices, or simply choices we now regret. But family and culture often attach one meaning to all of them: “You must have been careless.” If a parent was ashamed of owing money, or if people judged us for it, we may carry that verdict even when the facts are more complicated.

What Scripture teaches

Scripture is honest about debt. Proverbs says the borrower is slave to the lender, and it also values careful planning. But Scripture never says that owing money defines a person. Paul writes that there is now no condemnation for those who are in Christ Jesus. God knows our frame and is mindful that we are dust, and He has not dealt with us according to our sins. Where we did make poor choices, we can own them, learn, and move forward. Where we did not, we can let go of a verdict that was never ours to carry.

> *“Therefore, there is now no condemnation for those who are in Christ Jesus”* (Romans 8:1).

Also see

> “He has not dealt with us according to our sins or repaid us according to our iniquities” (Psalm 103:10).
>
> “For He knows our frame; He is mindful that we are dust” (Psalm 103:14).
>
> “The rich rule over the poor, and the borrower is slave to the lender” (Proverbs 22:7).
>
> “The plans of the diligent bring plenty, as surely as haste leads to poverty” (Proverbs 21:5).

Common self-statements

- Only careless people end up in debt.
- I should have known better.
- Everyone can see I cannot manage money.
- My debt shows what kind of person I am.
- If I were responsible, I would not owe.
- I have failed my family.

Common logical errors

- Labeling: Calling myself “irresponsible” instead of describing what happened.
- All-or-nothing thinking: Seeing myself as either totally responsible or a total failure with money.
- Personalization: Blaming myself for things that were outside my control, such as illness or layoffs.
- Mental filter: Focusing on the debt and ignoring the ways I have been responsible.

Challenging questions

- How did the debt actually happen, and which parts were choices and which were circumstances?
- What have I done responsibly, such as working, caring for others, or paying on time?

- Would I call a friend in my situation “irresponsible”?
- Where did I learn that debt equals failure?
- What does God say about my worth when I owe?
- What is one wise next step I can take without condemning myself?

Truth summary

> Owing money describes my account, not my character. Some of it may come from my choices and some from things I could not control. Either way, in Christ I am not condemned. I can be honest about the past, take wise steps now, and trust God’s mercy.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Guilt/Shame
- Money
- Forgiveness
- Mercy
- Grace

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Money/Riches
- Self-Esteem, Low

Listen: Overcoming Depression

> Overcoming Depression · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Clean — Natalie Grant
God’s cleansing grace challenges the belief that shame or sin makes a person beyond restoration.

East to West — Casting Crowns
God’s forgiveness addresses lingering guilt and fear of condemnation.

Grace Wins — Matthew West
Grace offers a new beginning rather than defining a person by failure.

Amazing Grace — Reawaken Hymns
This classic hymn locates salvation and sustaining hope in grace rather than merit.

Each morning ask: “If I truly believed God’s truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?”

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "My debt proves I'm irresponsible"

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Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"My debt proves I'm irresponsible." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ How did this debt happen?
- ☐ Which parts were choices and which were circumstances?
- ☐ What have I done responsibly?
- ☐ What label am I using on myself?
- ☐ What does God say about me?
- ☐ What is one wise step this week?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ My debt does not define me.
- ☐ There is no condemnation for me in Christ.
- ☐ I can be honest about what happened without attacking myself.
- ☐ Responsible people can still owe.
- ☐ God knows my frame and is mindful that I am dust.
- ☐ I can take one wise step at a time.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ Romans 8:1
  "Therefore, there is now no condemnation for those who are in Christ Jesus."
- ☐ Psalm 103:10
  "He has not dealt with us according to our sins or repaid us according to our iniquities."
- ☐ Psalm 103:14
  "For He knows our frame; He is mindful that we are dust."

A verse I found myself: _____

Practicing the Truth

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5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- ☐ Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- ☐ Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- ☐ Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- ☐ Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- ☐ Facts, not verdicts: Each day, write one fact about your money situation and one thing you did responsibly. Notice whether the harsh label softens.
- ☐ My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, Romans 8:1 becomes: "Sarah can write: "There is no condemnation for me in Christ, so I can face my debt honestly and take one wise step.""
- ☐ Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- ☐ Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- ☐ Reading: The "Guilt/Shame" topic in Pearls.
- ☐ Listening: The Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

This card is educational and is not financial or legal advice. Choose steps you can do safely. If you are without food, housing, or safety, contact your church, a trusted advisor, or local assistance services.

- ☐ Write the story honestly. List how the debt happened. Mark what was a choice, what was circumstance, and what you have learned.
- ☐ Replace the label. Cross out "irresponsible" and write a plain description, such as "I owe $X and I am making a plan."
- ☐ Take one practical step. Make a list of what you owe, or call one creditor, or schedule a visit with a trusted advisor or counselor.
- ☐ Say the verse aloud. Read Romans 8:1 each morning for a week.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

What I learned: _____

The lie "My debt proves I'm irresponsible": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	A responsible step
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~My debt proves I'm irresponsible.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Father, You know how my debt came about. Forgive what I need to be forgiven for, and free me from labels You do not give me. Help me take wise steps and rest in Your mercy. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.